



Past Its Own Date

A street-level test of whether a printed end date changes when a temporary notice comes down

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The problem

A taped-up notice — a closure, a detour, a lost pet — almost always carries its own printed end date. Despite that self-declared expiry, little is known about whether the date itself does any of the work of getting the notice taken down.

Research questions

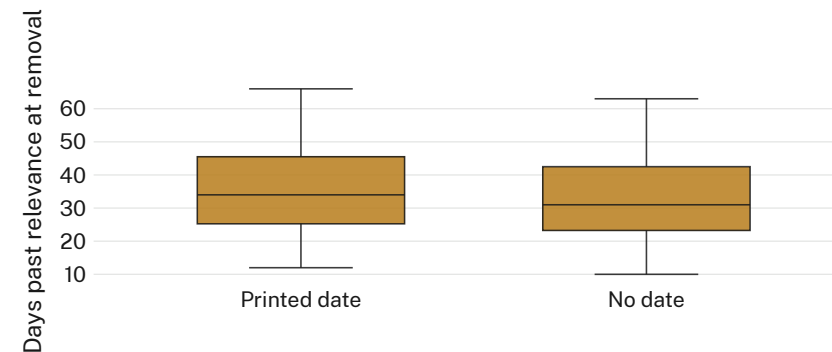
- Do dated notices come down closer to their stated date than matched undated notices come down after an equivalent interval?
- Does removal lag differ by notice type?
- Does the printed date function as a removal trigger, or as decoration?

Study design

- n = 214 taped notices · 9 suburbs · fortnightly walk-past photography · Feb–Jun 2026
- Matched-pairs design: each dated notice paired with an undated notice of the same type, posted within 3 days
- Removal criterion pre-registered: notice physically absent or fully obscured; no threshold adjusted post hoc

What we found

Dated and undated notices came down on statistically indistinguishable schedules. Both persisted, on average, more than a month past the point either council or University record marked them irrelevant.



Median removal lag: 34 days for dated notices vs 31 for undated (n = 214 matched pairs, Feb–Jun 2026); distributions statistically indistinguishable (Mann-Whitney U, p = 0.41).

Implications

The printed date reads as a courtesy to whoever posted the notice, not a cue anyone downstream acts on. Removal tracked visible weathering far more closely than any date printed on the sheet. A stated end appears to retire nothing by itself. Next: testing whether a notice's fade rate, not its date, is the operative removal signal.

Selected references

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No notices were removed or relocated by the research team; photography only, from public footpaths.

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“The date didn’t get it taken down. The weather did.”

Median removal lag: 34 days for dated notices vs 31 for undated (n = 214).